



Classic Shell is free and immensely configurable, a good bet

The Classic Shell start menu is a flexible, skinnable, highly configurable and best of all it is open source and free!

Visit www.classic-shell.net to download it (or find it on the Alpha DVD)

Pokki: This oddly named software is actually much more than just a start menu solution. If you are looking for an old fashioned menu that looks and works like the menus of yore, this might not be the best option for you. It is a very different menu both visually and functionally.

Pokki is actually a web application platform. So not only does it provide a menu, it also lets you install web applications and pin them to the taskbar. For example you can pin Gmail to your taskbar and it will show your inbox count on your taskbar, display notifications and will open in its own window. The start menu itself can integrate Facebook and Gmail and show notifications from both on the menu itself.

There are a number of other applications in the “Pokki store” including web games like Angry Birds. As a menu it serves well, and can search your installed metro and classic apps along with your files and web apps.

Start8: This is actually a paid software by Stardock the creators of software like WindowBlinds – and a few other software we cover later on – and costs a reasonable \$4.99. There is a free 30-day trial available though.

Start8 features two styles for the start menu, a Windows 7 style, and a Windows 8 style. The Windows 8 style of menu essentially resized the Windows 8 start screen to fit in a start menu-sized area so it works just like the Windows 8 start screen. The Windows 7 style menu supports a few different themes. The menu is quite configurable and is very stable and well integrated. Stardock has some experience with desktop customisation software after all. If you have a Stardock Object Desktop subscription, this is free.

Besides the three we’ve mentioned, there are other options such as **StartMenu8** by IObit or **ViStart**; although ViStart seems to be rife with third party toolbars and the like.